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Some Historic Sites in Nagpur District – Present Status

Abstract

Our Heritage is an indispensable part of our identity. Heritage conservation is viewed as a subject of utmost importance for national identity and for preserving the knowledge and arts of the past. According to UNESCO, culture and development cannot be, separated either in terms of economic growth or as a means of access to a satisfactory intellectual, moral and spiritual existence. Heritage conservation can be seen as a crosscutting factor in economic, social and environmental development. The sites, visible to us are either preserved to their original status or have been neglected due to – lack of resources, importance and awareness at local level. Constitution of India stipulates that it shall be the duty of every citizen of India to value and preserve the rich heritage of composite culture. We thus, have a special responsibility for preservation of our heritage as one of our fundamental duties. This research paper highlights some Historic sites of Nagpur district which need conservation and protection.

Keywords : Ambala-Talao, Bhugaon, Bhuyari, Hemadpanthi, Khopadi, Megaliths, Step Well, Vena, Wadoda

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हमारी धरोहरें हमारी पहचान के अविभाज्य अंग है। धरोहर संरक्षण राष्ट्रीय अस्मिता और अतीत की कला व ज्ञान के संरक्षण का एक महत्वपूर्ण कारक है। यूनेस्को के अनुसार संस्कृति और विकास को एक–दूसरे से पृथक नहीं किया जा सकता, न ही आर्थिक विकास के संदर्भ से और न ही बौद्धिक, नैतिक और आध्यात्मिक अस्तित्व के संतोषजनक पहुँच के रूप में। धरोहर संरक्षण को आर्थिक, सामाजिक और पर्यावरणीय विकास की काट के रूप में देखा जा सकता है। पुरास्थल; जो हमें दिखाई देते हैं वे या तो संरक्षित हैं या स्थानीय अज्ञानता और संसाधनों के अभाव के कारण उपेक्षित हैं। भारत के संविधान के अनुसार अपनी संस्कृति की मूल्यवान धरोहर के महत्व को समझना व उसका संरक्षण करना सभी भारतीय नागरिकों का कर्तव्य है। इसलिए हमारी धरोहरों का संरक्षण हमारा प्राथमिक कर्तव्य है। प्रस्तुत शोधपत्र नागपुर जिले में स्थित कुछ ऐतिहासिक स्थलों पर प्रकाश डालता है, जिन्हें संरक्षित व सुरक्षित किया जाना चाहिए।

i:e[k 'kCn %अम्बाला, तलाव, भूगाँव, भुयारी, हेमादपंथी, खोपड़ी, महा पाषाण, कुएं, वड़ोदा।

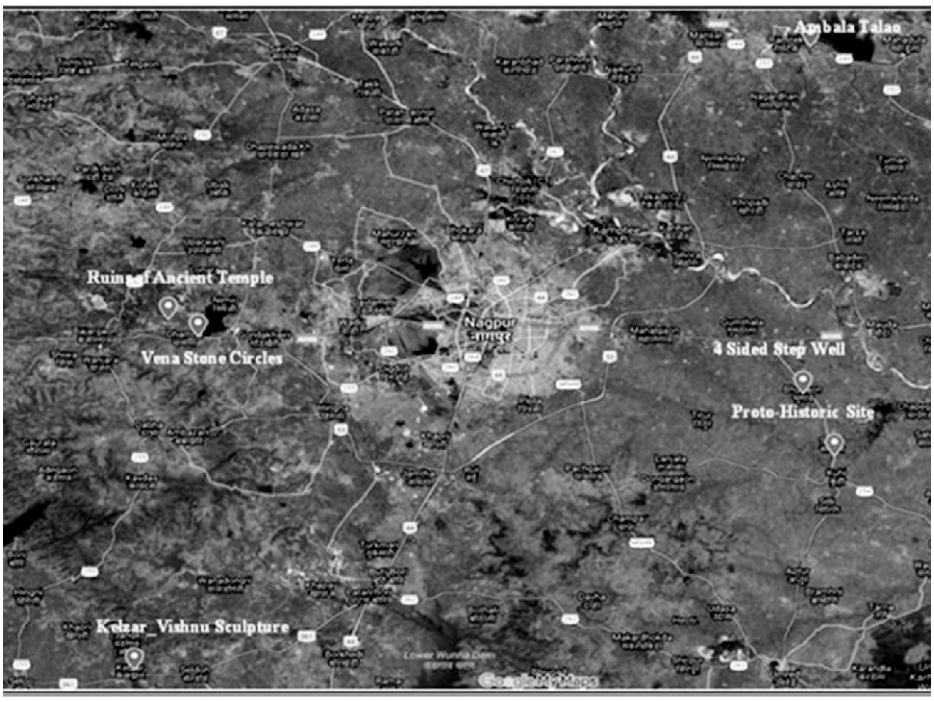


Fig. 1 : Google Map Showing Historic Sites Which Need Conservation

Figures : By the author



Fig. 2: Ambala Talao

1. Ambala Talao – Ramtek (210 23' 40'' N, 790 20' 48” E) - ASI-Category VI - Living monuments which receive large number of visitors/pilgrims [Table 1]



Fig. 3 : Hemadpanthi Temples on Banks of Ambala Talao.

Blackish water with Floating Debris of Flowers, Coconut Shells and Polythene Bags

Hemadpanti Sculpture (Many times spelled as Hemadpanthi) is an architectural style, named after its founder, the Prime Minister Hemadpant (1259-1274 C.E.) from the court of Seuna Yadavas of Devagiri. This building style was formed during the 13th Century in Maharashtra, and incorporated black stone and lime, which were readily available. (https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Hemadpanti-architecture &oldid=820944358).

2. Bhuyari Temple Ruins and Sculptures (210 9' 13" N, 49' 42" E) - ASI-Category VII -Monuments located in the Urban/semi urban limits and remote villages.[Table 1]



Fig. 4 : Structure with Four Remaining Pillars and Lintels



Fig. 5 : Collapsed Remains of Temple

Haphazard method of restoration, lintels precariously placed on pillars and white washed hiding all the original carvings and design can be seen in Fig.5.

Structural remains lying everywhere without proper care are bound to be stolen.



Fig. 6 : Collapsed Remains of Temple
(Intricately carved frieze, panels lying unattended amongst debris.)



Fig. 7 : Sculptures and Structural Parts
Sculptures, artifacts kept in open facing vagaries of nature.



Fig. 8 : Stone Circle in Foreground, Brick Kiln in the Background

3. Vena Megalithic Stone Circles (210 9' 13" N, 780 51' 44" E) - ASI-Category VII -Monuments located in the Urban/semi urban limits and remote villages [Table 1]



Fig. 9 : Intact Stone Circle in Foreground, Vena Reservoir and Cattle Grazing in Background

Megalithic Stone Circles (The term 'megalith' comes from two Greek words, "megas" meaning big and "lithos" meaning stone) are the early Iron Age burials from the middle of second millennium BCE. They reflect certain burial practices that surfaced at different times and in different regions. The forms and styles of megalithic burials as well as the funerary practices varied from region to region. They ranged from the extended burial to fractional, post excoriate and post-cremation burials. There are instances of burials containing the remains of more than one person. There are group-burials in family vaults. The presence of grave–goods points to a deep belief in after-life and at the same time reveals the main elements of material culture of the specific community. These mainly included weapons, pottery and ornaments.

Fig. 10 : Stone Circle



Present Condition

- Brick kiln operating right near stone circles, soil from stone circles is dug up for making bricks
- Stone Circles on the banks of water reservoir meant a religious or spiritual importance to Iron Age settlers, which has been, diluted due to urbanization and land used for cattle grazing and other activities, which invariably destroy the site.
- Stone Circle with shrubs and undergrowth, some stones missing

4. Bhugaon 4 Sided Step Well and Sculptures (210 5' 29" N, 790 20' 23" E) - ASI-Category VII -Monuments located in the Urban/semi urban limits and remote villages []

Step Wells

Wells in which, the water is reached by descending a, set of steps. They may be multi-storied with a bullock turning a water wheel to raise the well water to the first or second floor. They are most common in western India and are, found in the other more arid regions of the Indian subcontinent. The construction of step wells is mainly utilitarian, though they may include embellishments of architectural significance, and be temple tanks. Step wells are examples of the many types of storage and irrigation tanks that were, developed in India, mainly to cope with seasonal fluctuations in water availability. A basic difference between step wells on the one hand, and tanks and wells on the other, is to make it easier for people to reach the ground water and to maintain and manage the well. The builders dug deep trenches into the earth for dependable, year-round groundwater. They lined the walls of these trenches with blocks of stone, without mortar, and created stairs leading down to the water. The majority of surviving step wells originally served a leisure purpose as well as providing water. This was because the base of the well provided relief from daytime heat, and this was, increased if the well was

covered. Step wells also served as a place for social gatherings and religious ceremonies. Usually, women were more associated with these wells because they were the ones who collected the water. In addition, it was, they who prayed and offered gifts to the goddess of the well for her blessings. This led to the building of some significant ornamental and architectural features, often associated with dwellings and in urban areas. It also ensured their survival as monuments. Step wells usually consist of two parts: a vertical shaft from which, water is drawn and the surrounding inclined subterranean passageways, chambers and steps that provide access to the well. The galleries and chambers surrounding these wells carved with elaborate detail and became cool, quiet retreats during the hot summers. A number of distinct names exist for step wells. In Hindi-speaking regions, they include names based on baudi (including bawdi (Rajasthani: बावड़ी) awri, baoli, bavadi, and bavdi). In Gujarati and Marwari language, they are usually, called vav or vaav (Gujarati: વાવ). Other names include kalyani or pushkarani (Kannada), baoli (Hindi: बावली) and barav (Marathi: बारव).

History

The step well may have originated to ensure water during periods of drought. Steps to reach the water level in artificially constructed reservoirs can be found in the sites of Indus Valley Civilization Sites which have cylindrical brick lined wells which may be the predecessors of the step well. The first rock-cut step wells in India date from 200-400 AD. The earliest example of a bath-like pond reached by steps is, found at Uperkot caves in Junagadh. These caves are, dated to the 4th century. Navghan Kuvo, a well with circular staircase in the vicinity, is another example. It was possibly built in Western Satrap (200-400 AD) or Maitraka (600-700 AD) period, the step wells were constructed in the southwestern region of Gujarat around 600 AD; from there they spread north to Rajasthan and subsequently to north and west India. Initially used as an art form by

Hindus, the construction of these step wells hit its peak during Muslim rule from the 11th to 16th century. One of the earliest existing examples of step wells was, built in the 11th century in Gujarat. A long flight of steps leads to the water below a sequence of multi-story open pavilions positioned along the east/west axis. The elaborate ornamentation of the columns, brackets and beams are a prime example of how step wells were, used as a form of art. The Mughal rulers did not disrupt the culture practiced in these step wells and encouraged building of step wells.

Significance

The step well ensures the availability of water during periods of drought. The step wells had social, cultural and religious significance. These step wells were, proven well-built sturdy structures, after withstanding earthquakes.

Details

Many step wells have ornamentation and details as elaborate as those of Hindu temples do. Proportions in relationship to the human body were, used in their design, as they were in many other structures in Indian architecture. A number of surviving step wells can be, found across India, including in North Karnataka (Karnataka), Gujarat, Rajasthan, Delhi, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra.

Influence

Step wells are certainly one of India's most unusual, but little-known, contributions to architecture. They influenced many other structures in Indian architecture, especially many that incorporate water into their design.

Present Condition

- Step well used by locals for drying chillies/grains, dumping trash,
- Weeds growing on the sidewalls and steps and Algal formation in well water



Fig. 11 : Four Side Step Well



Fig. 12 : Four Side Step Well

Sculptures found nearby eroded by natural elements left in open and be stolen unless proper care is taken

Nandi covered with paint, damaged due to flaking of stone and cracks appearing due to seepage of chemicals.

5. Wadoda (210 7' 45" N, 790 19' 22" E) - ASI-Category VI - Living monuments which receive large number of visitors/pilgrims [Table 1]

- Entire step well covered with railing and used as garbage bin.
- Entrance of step well closed and is in disuse facing vagaries of nature.



Fig. 13 : Headless Laxmi-Narayan Sculpture



Fig. 14 : Unidentified Sculpture

➢ Entire well blocked by debris and trash, purpose of the well has been defeated (https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=stepwell&-oldid=841121321).



Fig. 15 : Nandi inside Vahan Mandap (Front Side View)



Fig. 16 : Nandi inside Vahan Mandap (Back Side View)

6. Khopadi-Early Iron Age Habitation Site (210 2' 3" N, 790 21' 56" E) - ASI-Category VII -Monuments located in the Urban/semi urban limits and remote villages [Table 1]

This site was partially, excavated in 2013, but still large area



Fig. 17 : One Sided Step Well



Fig. 18 : One Sided Step Well Opposite View



Fig. 19 : One Sided Step Well Top View

remained buried under farmland, until road-widening project came up in 2017, - section of exposed area showing potshards and different stratigraphic sequence, but mostly disturbed due to use of excavating machines. - exposed section showing farm field on the top with bottom sections showing different layers of soil with potshards. - Side view of exposed section trench dug for laying water pipeline, exposing different types of pottery (Pawar, *et.al.*, 2014 : 530-544).

Different types of potshards from

exposed sections, proving that this site had multicultural habitation.



Fig. 20 : Exposed Section

7. Kelzar (190 58' 0" N, 790 35' 0" E) - ASI-Category VI - Living monuments which receive large number of visitors/pilgrims [Table 1]



Fig. 21 : Exposed Section with Agricultural Field on the Top



Fig. 22 : Exposed Section Side View

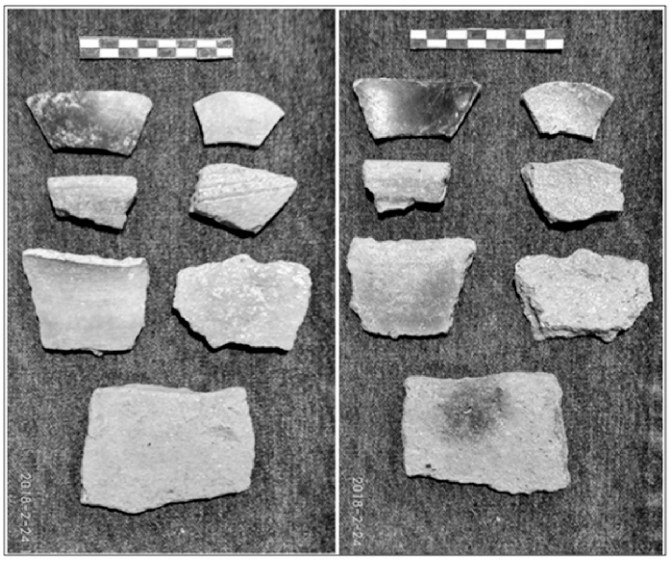


Fig. 23 : Pot Shards from Exposed Sections

This Beautifully carved intact Vishnu Sculpture was, found during clearing of surrounding area of the famous Siddhivinayak temple at Kelzar. Temple authorities fixed the sculpture into concrete wall on outside entrance of temple. Cement is slowly damaging sculpture along with the offerings, which is, smeared on to the deity. Sculpture should, have been given to museum authorities for proper upkeep



Fig. 24 : Vishnu Sculpture in Black Stone/Basalt

Key Concerns

Lack of knowledge and awareness about our cultural heritage in urban and rural areas has created a gap between identification and conservation of historical monuments, sites, artifacts. Most of them are at the mercy of local inhabitants. Over a period they are in disuse or destroyed or forgotten.

Laws for Protection of Historic Sites

1. The Indian Treasure Trove Act, 1878-First legislation of the ASI to protect and preserve treasure found accidentally, having archaeological and historical value.

2. The Ancient Monuments Preservation Act 1904 - To provide effective preservation and authority of the ASI over the monuments that are under the custody of individual or private ownership.

3. The Ancient and Historical Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains (Declaration of National Importance) Act, 1951

4. The Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains (AMASR) Act, 1958-Enacted on 28 August 1958 - provides for preservation of ancient and historical monuments, archaeological sites and remains of national importance, for regulation of archaeological excavations and for the protection of sculptures, carvings and other objects. The Act followed by AMASR Rules 1959.

5. The Antiquities and Art Treasures (AAT) Act 1972 - Enacted in September 1972 for effective control over moveable cultural property consisting of antiquities and art treasures, followed by AAT Rules 1973,

enforceable with effect from 5 April 1976

6. The AMASR (Amendment and Validation) Act, 2010-The Act prescribes the limits of regulated and prohibited area around monument by amending section 20 of AMASR Act 1958. It also provided for creation of National Monument Authority (A Report, 2013 : 21).

The Archeological Survey of India notified in 2011 that all the monuments were to be, categorized in following manner

Table 1 : Monument Categorization by Archeological Survey of India in 2011

Category I	World Heritage Sites
Category II	Tentative list of World Heritage Sites
Category III	Identified for inclusion in the World Heritage tentative list
Category IV	Ticketed monuments (other than mentioned above)
Category V	Identified for categorization as ticketed monuments
Category VI	Living monuments which receive large number of visitors/pilgrims
Category VII	Monuments located in Urban/semi urban limits and in remote villages
Category VIII	Other category as the Authority may deem fit

Conclusion

The Sites discussed herein come under the Laws governing to Historic Sites. Enforcing the law and by creating awareness at local level like–Sarpanch of Gram Panchayat/School and College Students/Local Leader/Village Seniors/Corporate, preservation and conservation will happen smoothly. The primary objective of managing heritage is to communicate its significance and need for its conservation to the host community and to the visitors. It would bring with it a duty of respect for the heritage values, interests and equity of the present-day host community, indigenous custodians or owners of historic property and for the landscapes and cultures from which that heritage evolved. A

protected monument or site would carry little meaning to common people if there were not enough resources to interpret and explain the cultural and historical significance. This Ongoing study on Status of Historical Monuments in and around Nagpur will enable enthusiasts / students / common person to understand about our vast socio cultural heritage, which in turn will help in conservation and preservation properly.

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